MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR/IMPROVEMENT/REAPPEARANCE

EXAMINATION NOVEMBER 2025

FIRST SEMESTER

Multi-Disciplinary Courses **(MDC) - MG1MDCPSY101 - PSYCHOLOGY OF SPORTS AND EXERCISE**

Duration: 1.5 Hours **Maximum Marks: 50**

Part A

Each Question carries **1** mark

1. The attentional problem is due to internal distraction (Nideffer's model ; internal and external direction) or cognitive interference when thoughts draw their attention away from important cues.

2. American Psychological Association (1986) is the organization first recognized sports psychology as a discipline.
However International Society Of Sports Psychology (1965) was founded earlier and served in the filed in formalizing the discipline

3. Jonh G Nicholls (task orientation and ego orientation), Carole Ames, Judith Duba, Andrew Elliot(approcah -avoidance), Maehr,G .C Roberts are the key proponents of achievement goal theory.

4. Amygdala, which is known as emotional alarm syytem is the key part of the limbic system responsible for detecting fear, threat, anger.

5. Contagion means the spread of emotion or behaviour from one person to other, Fans often mirror each other's excitement or frustration, producing shared emotional reactions.Spectators unconsciously imitate expressions and vocal cues, creating a collective mood that intensifies the stadium atmosphere.

6.According to Nideffer's Attentional Style Model (1976) a golfer preparing to putt requires a **Narrow–External attentional focus,** because they must concentrate on a single external cue—the ball—while excluding all distractions.

7. Eustress is a positive form of stress that increases arousal and motivation. Eustress is enjoyable stress that fans experience during tense or exciting moments in a game. It creates pleasurable arousal and excitement, making sports watching more thrilling .

8. Fandom involves identification with teams, emotional reactions, and collective experiences shared with other spectators. Fans gain social identity and excitement through their support.
Fandom is referred as a strong psychological bond with a sport or team, influencing emotions, mood, behaviour, and even daily life. Fans experience belongingness and motivation through their favourite teams.

9. Attentional Cueing, Pre-Performance Routines ,Self-Talk,Mental Imagery / Visualization,Mindfulness Training,Progressive Muscle Relaxation (PMR),Simulation Training,Focus Drills,Thought-Stopping Technique

10. Mastery (Task) Goal Orientation, explained under Achievement Goal Theory (Nicholls) focuses on learning and personal improvement

Part B

Multiple Choice Questions

Answer **All** Questions

Each Question carries **1** mark

11.B. A growing focus on mindfulness and psychological resilience
12.B. They help individuals respond appropriately to challenges and opportunities.
13.B.Thought stopping.
14.A Familiarity with the playing conditions,
15.C. Diehard fans maintain loyalty even after losses
16.C A weightlifter working out vigorously
17.A The team's geographical proximity to the fan.
18.C In a high-stakes competition with a large audience
19.B Self-mastery
20.D.It enhances self-esteem and motivation.

Part C

Short Answer Questions |Answer any **8** Questions| Each Question carries **2** marks

21. Independent Variable– the condition the researcher manipulates (e.g., type of training).
Dependent Variable– the performance outcome measured to see effect of the IV (e.g., reaction time).

22. Focusing attention on task-relevant cues (e.g., breathing, target, technique) helps athletes block intrusive negative thoughts. Thought stopping with attentional cueing are recommended techniques.Attentional focusing helps to block negative thoughts by directing focus into task relevant activities,

23. Effective routines keep your mind on the tasks and not become distracted bt all the irrelavant things around you. Without a set of routine the hours before the game would be random series of events, and focus will be unpredictable. Routines prevent other things entering mind. They increase the likelihood that you will be focused and ready for performance.
Ideal time:performed immediately before the skill (e.g., before a free throw or serve) and are brief to avoid overthinkingRoutines are not carved in stones . you will want to evaluate periodically and adjust them. There are routines before practice,during practice, after practice, game day routines .

24.Role-related behaviour is shaped by situational demands—coach expectations, team norms, audience, and context. Jarvis notes that athletes alter behaviour to fit "roles" required by the environment.

25.According to Nideffer’s Attentional Model shifting attentional focus means moving between broad and narrow or internal and external depending on task needs.Effective shifting improves decision-making, adaptability, and performance.

26.Situational readiness means the athlete’s optimal emotional state(confidence, appropriate arousal, focus) before performance.This readiness predicts whether performance will be enhanced or impaired.

27.Positive thinking lead to positive emotional reactions. For eg for the positive self talk: I did it , it was all the worth it , the resulting emotional reaction would be relief.
ABC model by Albert Ellis also emphasized positive thinking.
If our self talk is positive, you will experience corresponding changes in the body and performance will improve.Positive thinking boosts self-confidence, reduces fear of failure, and enhances intrinsic motivation. It promotes persistence and effort, key motivators in sport.

28.Extraversion - energetic, inspiring coaching
Agreeableness -cooperative, supportive coach–athlete relationships
Conscientiousness -organised, disciplined coaching
Neuroticism (low)- emotionally stable coaching
Openness to experience -flexible, creative strategies
Personality influences communication and leadership effectiveness.

29.Emotion is a coordinated psychological response involving:

1. Physiological arousal (automatic bodily changes)
2. Cognitive appraisal (interpretation of situation)
3. Behavioural expression(action tendencies, facial expressions)

Emotion is defined as complex reaction pattern, involving experiential, behavioral and physiological elements," that an individual uses to deal with a personally significant matter or event.(APA) and can include other definitions of emotion

30.The core mechanism is the athlete's subjective evaluation (appraisal) of an event in a specific context
Intensity: The significance an athlete places on a situation directly affects emotional intensity.
Type: The context determines which specific emotion is experienced.

31.**Need for Belonging and Identity:** Humans have an innate need to belong to groups for a sense of community, meaning, and security.
Social Identity Theory: This theory explains that individuals derive part of their self-worth and self-esteem from their group memberships. To maintain a positive self-image, fans often highlight the superiority of their own team (in-group) and devalue rival teams (out-group).
Basking in Reflected Glory (BIRGing): Fans boost their self-esteem by associating themselves with their team's successes, often using "we" to describe a win .
Out-group Hostility: Intense loyalty to one's own group naturally leads to rivalry and sometimes hostility toward opposing fans.
Social and cultural factors,shared rituals and symbols,historical and geographic Grievances: Long-standing rivalries are often tied to city, regional, or even national histories and cultural differences

32. Achievement behavior is primarily discussed within the framework of achievement motivation theory. Definition: Achievement motivation is a person's desire to strive for satisfaction when making comparisons with some standard of excellence.

A central tenet is that behavior have influence on athlete's personality (trait-centered view) or the situation itself (situation-centered view).
Need Achievement Theory: explain how personality traits and situational demands combine to shape an athlete's emotional responses and drive behavior. It posits that people are motivated by either a desire for success or a fear of failure.
Achievement Goal Theory (AGT): identifies two primary goal orientations:
Task/Mastery Orientation: Athletes focus on self-improvement, mastering the skill, and achieving personal bests (e.g., a personal best in running).
Ego/Outcome Orientation: Athletes focus on outperforming others and winning. Success is defined by social comparison. This can be less stable and more prone to negative emotions (anxiety) if the athlete perceives their ability as low or faces a superior opponent.

33.The brain's reward system affects motivation in athletics by using dopamine pathways to reinforce behaviors that lead to positive outcomes, such as achieving goals, receiving social approval, and experiencing the intrinsic satisfaction of exercise.
Dopamine Release and Reinforcement: The brain's reward system, releases dopamine in response to rewarding experiences. In an athletic context, this happens when an athlete achieves a personal best wins a competition, or even just completes a tough training session. This surge of dopamine creates a sense of pleasure and reinforces the behavior, making the athlete want to repeat the activity.
Goal-Directed Action (Motivation): The prospect of a future reward (e.g., winning a medal, improving performance) is a strong motivator. Social recognition, such as praise from a coach, applause from a crowd, or peer acceptance, also activates the same reward circuits as more tangible rewards.

Part D

Long Answer Type Questions| Answer any **2** Questions| Each Question carries **7** marks

34.Assessment of Attentional Skills in Sports Psychology
Attentional skills refer to an athlete's ability to focus, sustain concentration, and appropriately direct attention during performance.
Methods of Assessment

1. Self-Report Questionnaires
2. Behavioral Observation
3. Performance Measures:

Effective vs. Ineffective Attentional Styles(based on Nideffers theory)
Athletes use four main attentional styles: broad external, narrow external, broad internal, and narrow internal. Each of these can be effective or ineffective depending on how they are used.
1. **Broad External Focus**
Effective: Helps athletes take in a wide range of external cues—useful in team sports (e.g., tracking players, opponents, and ball movement).
Ineffective:Can become overwhelming if too many external cues are processed without filtering.
2. **Narrow External Focus**
Effective:Useful for precision tasks (e.g., penalty kick, archery) by focusing on a single key cue.
Ineffective: Over-fixation on one cue may cause athletes to miss other important situational information.
3. **Broad Internal Focus**
Effective: Helps in planning, analyzing body movements, and strategizing during performance.
Ineffective:May lead to overthinking, self-doubt, and mental clutter.
4. **Narrow Internal Focus**

Effective:Useful for mental rehearsal, visualization, and emotional control before/during performance.
Ineffective: If overused, can lead to self-criticism, anxiety, and disruption of automatic skills.
No single style is best for all situations. However, Narrow External Focus is generally considered the most effective during actual performance, because it helps athletes focus on the most relevant cue (e.g., the ball, target, or movement).Broad External is also highly effective in dynamic sports where situational awareness is crucial.

35.Situational emotions refer to the emotional responses individuals experience in reaction to specific contexts, environments, or events. Understanding emotions requires examining how athletes' feelings change depending on competitive settings, social factors, and task demands
1. Nature of the Task or Competition
Different tasks generate different emotional demands:High-pressure competitions may trigger anxiety, fear, or excitement .Simple or familiar tasks may create calmness or confidence
2. Social Environment
Emotions are influenced by:Audience presence ,Coach behavior , Team dynamics
3. Personal Meaning
Emotions intensify when the athlete interprets the situation as highly important.
4. Perceived Control
Perceived ability to handle a situation determines emotional reactions.For eg: Feeling in control - confidence, determination ,Feeling overwhelmed - anxiety, frustration
5. Past Experiences and Expectations
Previous success or failure in similar situations strongly colors emotional responses.
Situational emotions like anxiety or confidence can directly affect: motor performance, decision making,attention and focus. Understanding these emotions helps psychologists optimize performance in athletes.Situations that trigger positive emotions (e.g., pride, excitement) increase motivation, while negative emotions (e.g., fear or frustration) can decrease effort or lead to withdrawal.Understanding situational emotions allows psychologists to: teach coping strategies, develop emotional regulation skills,train athletes to reinterpret stress as challenge. They provide insight into human adaptation

Importance for Psychological Research: Studying situational emotions is crucial because: Researchers must understand how and why emotions change with circumstances to accurately study human behavior.
Situational emotion research contributes to: cognitive appraisal theories,stress models,motivation theories.
Behavior is not stable across all situations. Research that incorporates situational emotion provides a more realistic understanding of human functioning. Findings help psychologists create:training programs, counseling strategies, performance enhancement techniques.

36.Psychology is used in sports because human performance is influenced not only by physical abilities **but also by mental and emotional factor**s. One major reason psychology is used in sports is to **enhance performance**. Psychological skills such as imagery, goal setting, and positive self-talk help athletes sharpen their mental focus and improve execution of skills during competition.Another important area is **managing stress and anxiety.** Sport psychology teaches athletes techniques for relaxation, breathing control, and cognitive restructuring, helping them stay calm and composed even in high-pressure moments. **Motivation** is another key factor studied in sport psychology. Athletes need strong motivation to persist through long training hours, injuries, setbacks, and competition failures.

Psychology also plays a role in helping athletes regulate their **emotions**. Learning emotional control improves concentration, decision-making, and overall consistency.Another important use of psychology is improving focus and **attention.** Training attention helps them block out distractions such as crowd noise, pressure, or negative thoughts, which is essential for skill execution.

37.Perceived competence refers to an athlete's belief in their ability to perform successfully in a sport situation. This concept is best explained through **Achievement Goal Theory, proposed by Nicholls.** Wh**en athletes feel competent, they experience higher intrinsic motivation,** take on challenging tasks, and show persistence even during setbacks. This leads to better focus, lower anxiety, and improved performance.
Achievement Goal Theory states that athletes adopt two main orientations: **task-oriented and ego-oriented.** These orientations influence how they evaluate their competence.
Task-oriented athletes judge their competence based on personal improvement, learning, and effort. They focus on mastering skills rather than comparing themselves with others. Because their perception of competence depends on internal standards, it remains stable even when they face strong opponents or experience failure. As a result, task-oriented athletes stay motivated, persist longer, enjoy their sport more, and experience lower anxiety. They view challenges as opportunities for growth.
Ego-oriented athletes, on the other hand, judge their competence by comparing themselves to others. For them, success means outperforming opponents or being seen as talented. Their perceived competence depends on external comparisons, which makes it fragile. When ego-oriented athletes believe they can win, their motivation is high. However, when they face stronger competitors or fear being outperformed, their perceived competence decreases quickly. This can lead to anxiety, avoidance of challenging tasks, and inconsistent performance. They may even choose easier tasks to protect their image of ability.